

access funds for the under-privileged.

- Donald Trump, the current president, has vowed to reverse many of these, winning support from mostly white, right wing Americans who consider such initiatives unfair. In addition, Trump has insulted other countries (including many in Africa), and refused to condemn violent racist attacks in American cities.
- Worrying statistics about the amount of unarmed 'people of colour' (POC) shot by US police led to the **#blacklivesmatter** campaign, which has utilised **social media** to raise awareness of an issue that has often been ignored by **mainstream media**.

Consider the significance of patterns of ownership and control, including conglomerate ownership, vertical integration and diversification:

- *Black Panther* was produced by Marvel Studios, who became a subsidiary of Disney in 2008. They are also the film's **distributor**, which makes this a good example of **vertical integration**.
- Marvel has historically sold **options** on individual characters or comicbook titles e.g. Spiderman to TV and then to Paramount (and who is still partly owned by Sony). *Black Panther* was one of those owned fully by Marvel; in 2009 a new team began developing T'Challa and lesser known characters.
- In early 2000s, Marvel Studios began to **produce** films, starting with *Blade* (1998) and the *X-Men* films (2000).
- When Disney bought Marvel, they agreed to minimal creative influence over Marvel products.
- in 2013, Marvel also signed a deal with **streaming** service Netflix to develop TV series for six more characters (including *Daredevil* and *Punisher* who had already been made into films). This may have caused conflict with Disney, who has their own streaming channel, and in 2019 Netflix cancelled their Marvel shows.

Consider how media organisations maintain, including through marketing, varieties of audiences nationally and globally:

- Disney, the film's **distributor** adopted a '360-degree consumer experience' to their marketing (i.e. wherever you look, there's *Black Panther*!)
- The concept was to make the film into a '**cultural event**' across a variety of media and platforms and raising its profile

from being 'another superhero' film into something more **politically resonant**.

- Here are some of the **brand association** deals Disney used to target a **diverse audience** who may not be 'fanboys'. How do these a.) appeal to a different spectator than other Marvel films?: Hasbro toys <https://io9.gizmodo.com/this-black-panther-toy-commercial-is-moreimportant-tha-1821802836> ; Lexus cars <https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/lexus-introduces-two-newvehicles-inspired-by-marvel-studios-black-panther-ahead-of-sema-2017-300542095.html> Interscope records (Universal Music) <https://www.factmag.com/2018/02/13/ryancoogler-kendrick-lamar-black-panther/> and b.) how do they combine in a **synergy** to make *Black Panther* 'more' than a superhero film?
- Black Panther's teaser trailers were shown between NBA games and a special collaboration with Lexus called 'Long Live The King' was shown during the Superbowl. What kind of audiences normally watch these programmes? How are they different to the usual Marvel **fanbase**?
- The film's release also harnessed a political element to add gravitas. **Crowd-funding** projects to buy under-privileged children a ticket won support from celebrities; the film was released during **Black History Month**; plus Coogler, the stars and the costume, hair/make-up, production designers all gave detailed interviews about how the film celebrates African culture. <https://www.theatlantic.com/entertainment/archive/2018/02/why-fashion-is-key-tounderstanding-the-world-of-black-panther/553157/>
- There was also a 'Welcome to Wakanda' catwalk show at New York Fashion Week and features in numerous fashion magazines. (On opening weekend 44% of ticket buyers were female)
- Look at the preview posters and the trailer - (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xjDjIWPwcPU>) - how does the film celebrate African culture? Why might it be important to black children to have characters like Black Panther? How does it also represent black women in a powerful way? How does it also appeal to fans of blockbusters?
- Disney are adept at identifying **nuanced demographic** groups and strategies for targeting them. Many of their products are '**intercultural**' i.e. they strongly represent one cultural tradition but in a way that resonates with audiences from other cultural / national / ethnic backgrounds.